

SERIAL LAUNCH
Mamata Banerjee unveils the Duare Ration scheme, Nov. 2021

ANI

THE DOLE CALL

Welfare schemes in focus in Mamata's third term

LAKSHMIR BHANDAR
Monthly income support for women
Annual outlay: Rs 16,000 crore
Beneficiaries: 16 million

SWASTHYA SATHI
Free health insurance of up to Rs 5 lakh a year
Annual outlay: Rs 2,000 crore
Beneficiaries: 75 million

KHADYA SATHI
Subsidised ration for all
Annual outlay: Rs 5,000 crore
Beneficiaries: 90 million

KRISHAK BANDHU & KISAN CREDIT CARD
Crop insurance and loans for farmers
Annual outlay: Rs 5,000 crore
Beneficiaries: 6.2 million

MATSYAJIBI CREDIT CARD
A new loan scheme for fishing communities
Annual outlay: Yet to be announced
Beneficiaries: 600,000 (targeted)

STUDENT CREDIT CARD
Loans of up to Rs 10 lakh for higher studies
Outlay: Rs 54 crore spent so far
Beneficiaries: 14,000 so far

Source: West Bengal government

expanding her basket of doles. Populist schemes demand higher outlays over the years," says a senior West Bengal official, requesting anonymity.

Sukhendu Sekhar Ray, Rajya Sabha MP and TMC national spokesperson, counters: "India being a welfare state, social security should be a priority. Mamata Banerjee is a people's leader and the Trinamool a people's party." Ray blames the Modi government for Bengal's financial woes. "The Union government has centralised almost all financial powers. Unless 50 per cent from the central pool comes to the states, they will continue to battle financial problems," he says.

With the government struggling to generate resources, capital expenditure and departmental allocations have been slashed. Work on 10 new universities, announced in 2016, including a second campus for Calcutta University and Presidency University, has stopped. "Construction of around 800 schools and expansion of roads and bridges are on hold. The government is struggling to make the promised payments to Covid frontline workers," says a senior official.

"In the age of competitive federalism, falling capex will send wrong signals and harm the prospects of attracting industry," says Dr Nilanjan Ghosh, director, Centre for New Economic Diplomacy, Observer Research Foundation. "Already, the shadows of the Singur and Nandigram land agitations hang over the government."

Nor are all of Mamata's pet projects on track. Of the 114,000 applicants for the Student Credit Card, only 14,000 secured loans. While seven banks have joined the scheme, the West Bengal State Cooperative Bank is wary. "The government standing guarantor is not enough. The scheme itself is unviable. School students, even non-meritorious ones, passing 10th and 12th grades, are applying for loans without any career plans. We need to assess the repayment viability," says an officer of the bank. The move to expand Swasthya Sathi has also drawn flak. "Private hospitals are hesitant to admit patients with Swasthya Sathi cards as previous bills are pending with the government," says Dr Kunal Sarkar, a noted cardiologist in Kolkata. The Duare Ration scheme, with an outlay of Rs 1,200 crore, has also run into rough weather, with some 1,000 of the 21,000 ration dealers demanding more compensation for home delivery.

The state government's Rs 3.21 lakh crore budget for the 2022-23 fiscal has steered clear of any big announcements for new schemes since the state, which was supposed to generate a revenue of Rs 75,415 crore as per the 2021-22 budgetary proposal, ended up with a shortfall of Rs 1,600 crore. Allotment for just four departments—panchayat and rural development, women and child development, social welfare, and tribal welfare and agriculture—has been scaled up to Rs 56,900 crore since these are directly involved in funding popular schemes like Lakshmir Bhandar and Kanyashree, among others.

This January, Bengal borrowed an additional Rs 6,500 crore from the market. Can Mamata then afford to push ahead with her brand of popular yet profligate welfarism? Dr Ghosh warns that it's time for some pragmatism. "Schemes like Lakshmir Bhandar, which cater to specific audiences, do not qualify as social security. The government, while being populist, is not implementing the 6th Pay Commission recommendations. The pay scales of state government staff are now the second lowest in the country," he says. A little caution may not be amiss. ■